

Exploring trust in flexible working using a new model

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Information technology (IT) facilitates novel forms of communication between individuals and organisations, thus supporting new flexible work patterns and making organisational boundaries more permeable. In general, this increases the physical and cultural distances both within and between organisations choosing to work together. In all of these situations, trust is a critical part of the process by which relationships develop. This paper presents a model of the trust development process called the ABC Trust Model. It is based on a synthesis of the management and information systems literature. The model is illustrated by applying it to a case example of remote working between individuals within an organisation. It is also demonstrated that the ABC Trust Model can be applied more generally to the fostering of co-operative relationships between both individuals and organisations that are supported by shared information systems. It is therefore of value to researchers investigating trust and also to managers involved in the design and implementation of IT-based co-operative relationships. The implications for new information systems design are discussed and opportunities for future research are outlined.

1. Introduction

An increasingly competitive global business environment has radically increased user demand for customisation of products and services, new product development and lower prices. To cope with these new challenges, organisations have begun to implement innovative systems and businesses such as contracting, horizontal co-operation within and between organisations, and flexible (remote) working [1]. Such economic and business changes require an increasing degree of trust between individuals. This is partly due to the increased risks involved when people collaborate without being collocated. At the same time western society's social capital (i.e. the fund of trust and goodwill in any social group that enables people within it to collaborate with each other without having to first write a voluminous legal agreement) is thought to be decreasing [2, 3]. This means that organisations have to create their own social capital rather than relying on employees' altruism and natural propensity to trust [2].

Trust existing between individuals, and their expected behaviour, can be explored using trust models. These can be used by people who are designing and introducing systems — such as products and services, business reorganisations, and new ways of working — into organisations, in order to increase the chances of successful implementation.

In this paper a trust model is applied to flexible working. The trust model takes into account an individual's or an organisation's tendency to trust, the situation in which actions which demonstrate that trust is needed, and the

consequences of applying trust. The trust aspects of flexible working that are looked at include how managers can trust individuals without working with them face-to-face, what enables remote workers to trust their managers to treat them fairly and to what extent flexible workers can trust technology to do their work more effectively.

2. The importance of trust

A major organisational implication of innovative work practices is the increase in physical distance between people who work together. The lack of presence and visibility and the general turmoil generated by change within organisations can lead to a feeling of distrust and vulnerability. At the same time the increase in physical distance is a key opportunity for the deployment of new telecommunications products and services. These can overcome some of the problems of physical separation, but this can only be done successfully if people feel at ease using them.

One of the characteristics of innovative work practices and alliances is that they often combine elements of co-operation and competition [4], adding to the participant's perceptions of risk and precariousness.

Trust within organisations is an extremely complex and dynamic phenomenon [5]. For example an employee may trust his co-workers but distrust his supervisor or top management. Trust is dynamic — it changes over time based on new evidence of people's expectations and behaviours.

Trust can be viewed from a number of different perspectives. It can be defined as a hybrid phenomenon, between calculation and predictability on the one hand, and goodwill and voluntary exposure to the risk that the trustee might cheat, on the other hand [6].

Trust can also be described in terms of social capital. It is thus fundamental to organisational success. Disturbingly, social capital in western society is decreasing more rapidly than it is being created. A recent report found that UK employees respected management less than employees of any other European country [2]. The report stated that employees cease to respect managers because of their propensity for greed.

Trust and security have a symbiotic relationship to each other [2]. For example, there is a danger that if people feel insecure and are willing to go to any lengths to retain their jobs, they may assume that others feel the same way. The questioning of others' motives may cause trust between co-workers, let alone towards their managers, to be diminished. Conversely, if people feel secure they are more likely to take the risk involved in trusting someone else and also more likely to perceive others as trustworthy.

By understanding and using trust models it is hoped that systems designers will be able to foresee whether trust is likely in a given situation. They should also be able to predict whether trust is likely to break down and why. This may enable them to design systems that encourage trusting relationships between people, e.g. facilitating co-operation between people working at a distance.

3. The ABC Trust Model

The development of the ABC Trust Model [7] is discussed below. The ABC Trust Model derives its name from three main components:

- antecedents,
- behavioural elements,
- consequences.

These elements are defined and explained in the following sections.

3.1 Trust antecedents

The earliest work on trust focused on individuals and used a psychological perspective [8–12]. From this research, it is possible to identify two related types of trust — innate or disposition to trust, and subjective trust.

Innate trust is the natural tendency of individuals, based on their attitudes, personality and previous experiences, to trust other people (Fig 1). It is independent of a specific



Fig 1 In the context where people share positive past experiences and have knowledge of each other's skills and abilities, it will be easier to build trusting relationships.

situation and is a measure of an individual's tendency to trust or distrust. A person's disposition is unlikely to change very quickly over time. In the same way that an individual can be said to be trusting or not, Barney and Hansen [9] identify the concept of whether an individual or organisation is 'trustworthy', i.e. deserving of trust by another. Again, this is independent of a specific situation and is based typically on reputation and knowledge of others' typical actions.

Subjective trust is specific to a particular situation, wherein the question of what constitutes trust changes from being a general measure of innate trust to being a more specific measure of subjective trust. For example, 'Do you trust other people?' changes to 'Do you trust X to behave in a particular way in this situation?' These situational factors that affect the trust relationship are referred to as the 'situational context' and include the following:

- the nature of the task being considered,
- how much the person knows about the other partners involved (e.g. trustworthiness) [10, 11],
- what power relationships exist and how they are likely to change in a given situation,
- what the incentives are for parties to make a proposition successful,
- how much shared background or experience participants have which causes them to trust a system or a person as a consequence,
- whether or not the necessary people, technology and skills are in place to engender trust.

Innate trust and the situational context form the first component of the ABC Trust Model referred to as trust antecedents and shown in Fig 2.

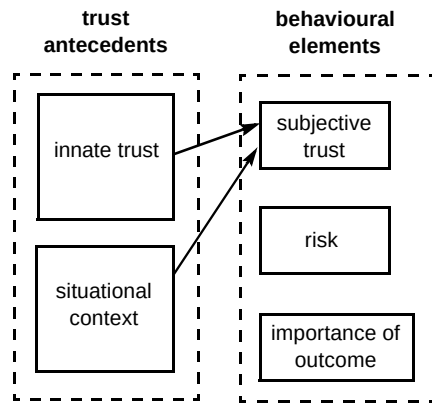


Fig 2 Trust antecedents and behavioural elements.

3.2 Behavioural elements

Subjective trust is the mental state that influences the behaviour of an individual and is mediated by the specific nature of the transaction. The actual behaviour of an individual towards an economic partner is a function of subjective trust, risk that their trust might be misplaced, and the importance of the outcome. For example, even though the level of subjective trust is low and the risk of mistrust is high, an individual may choose, quite rationally, to display 'trusting behaviour' towards an economic partner when the importance of the outcome is extremely low and there is little to lose. Behaviour and trust are therefore independent concepts. The influence of trust on behaviour is mediated by the perceived risk of the situation and the importance of the outcome [12]. This leads to the formation of the behavioural elements component in the ABC Trust Model, which consists of subjective trust, risk and the importance of the outcome (Fig 2).

3.3 Trust consequences

The result of deciding whether or not to trust a particular person, software agent, system or organisation in a given situation will have many consequences. These consequences may take the form of transactions between different economic actors, information exchange, investment in an individual/organisation or implementation of a system or idea. These consequences form the third ABC Trust Model component.

The consequences of the situation are monitored (often sub-consciously) and any new knowledge about behaviour, attitudes or capabilities directly affects the situational context. Following a situation where trust is displayed, the people involved will evaluate their own and others' experiences and decide whether to continue their co-operation and if so, in what form [13]. For example, following the actions of others, people may become more trusting resulting in better relationships. Thus, the relationship between trust and behaviour of economic partners is dynamic — it changes over time. For example,

given two companies *A* and *B*, the subjective trust of *A* is influenced by the behaviour of *B*. This in turn may affect the behaviour of *A* which then influences the subjective trust of *B* towards *A* and so on. This type of circular process relationship has been identified in both the marketing literature and the organisation behaviour literature on research into the formation of business relationships [13, 14]. Therefore the model must encompass a mechanism for feeding back perceptions of consequences. Monitoring of performance is the fourth component of the model.

In summary, Fig 3 shows the four components that make up the ABC Trust Model and shows the relationship between them.

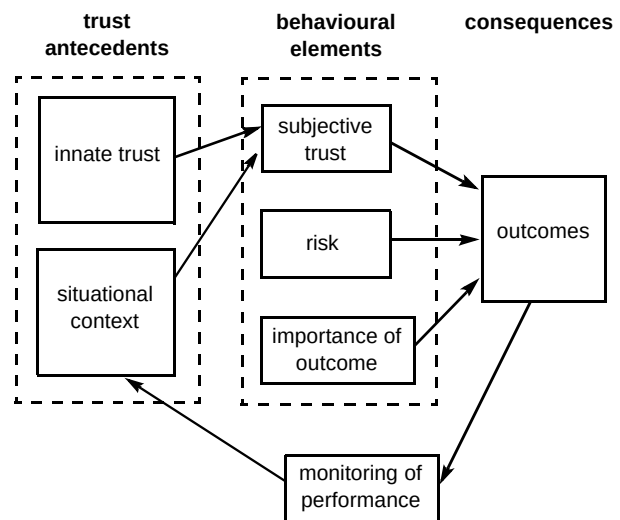


Fig 3 ABC Trust Model.

The components of the model allow it to be used in various situations from understanding the communication between individuals through to exploring behaviour within society. The model can be used in two main ways:

- designers and developers can use it to systematically think through the issues of trust that may arise within a particular context where they are going to introduce a new system,
- they may use it to explore a situation, that is similar to the one in which they are interested, where an existing system has already been implemented, to see what trust issues existed and how these were overcome.

Both methods of using the ABC Trust Model, or preferably a combination of the two, will enable systems designers and developers to improve the design of organisational systems to encourage people to collaborate.

4. An example of the ABC Trust Model in use

Having developed the ABC Trust Model, the next stage was to validate it for completeness and ease of application. A recent case study of how a group of people successfully implemented flexible working was selected for this purpose. The model was used to explore trust between employees involved in flexible working and their managers. Validation using an example, where the outcome was known to be positive, allowed investigation into whether the model covered all aspects needing to be considered for successful implementation of a new system. A future stage will be to apply it to the implementation of a new system where the outcome is unknown to see if the model can predict successfully where issues of trust may occur.

For many people, working remotely has become their everyday life. These people are known as flexible workers. The ABC Trust Model will be used in retrospect to examine trust issues that exist between managers and flexible workers, and will explore how flexible working systems could be designed or improved to engender trust.

Employees involved in office-based work and their managers have generally tended to meet face to face. This increases their chances of forming trusting relationships because they are more likely to develop a mutual understanding of what is expected. They are also more likely to form a bond based on mutual respect than they would if they were not collocated. Advances in technology have resulted in more frequent communication with people who are physically remote. Work has become an activity that can take place at any location.

An important issue is the level of comfort individuals feel when they are expected to co-operate, using technology, with people whom they may never physically meet. Increased physical distance also affects the chances of building and maintaining trusting relationships.

Flexible working covers a broad spectrum of workers and activities. This case discusses a total of fourteen autonomous workers, many of who were originally collocated with each other and with colleagues who remained office-based after the introduction of flexible working [15]. Even in this situation, where a large degree of trust previously existed, people still had concerns about starting flexible working. The ABC Trust Model was applied in retrospect at the point where the flexible workers decided whether or not to start flexible working. It was used to examine potential issues of trust between remote workers and their managers and shows how flexible working was designed and introduced to minimise these issues. When people had been flexibly working for 18 months the consequences of flexible working were examined [16], in the light of the model's predictions. Also the effect of the consequences that fed back into the situational context are

assessed to show how trust develops over time. Data before and during the flexible working pilot were collected using questionnaires and face-to-face interviews. Following each of the data collection periods, findings relating to the model components and attributes, such as previous experience, attitude, risk and behaviour were examined.

The case study is described below in terms of each of the components of the trust model. The trust antecedents and behavioural components allow the model to be used systematically to explore flexible workers' and managers' experiences, perceived risks and expected behaviour. The consequences will be discussed with reference to three key questions.

- How can managers trust individuals to work effectively without face-to-face supervision?
- What enables individuals to trust managers to treat them fairly compared with their more visible office-based colleagues?
- To what extent can flexible workers trust their technology to help them work effectively?

These questions have been used to focus the use of the model on specific aspects of the flexible worker/manager relationship.

4.1 Trust antecedents

The trust antecedents component consists of innate and situational trust which, taken together, summarise the history and current status of the flexible workers' and managers' relationship. Innate trust is inferred from the natural tendency of the individual or organisation to trust others. The level of innate trust is combined with situational factors, such as the nature of the task and knowledge of the economic partner, to produce an overall level of trust.

Innate trust

Personality, culture and attitudes all contribute towards innate trust. These can all be affected over time by previous experience. This study, is based on people at BT's London Software Engineering Centre (LSEC). In this case study, the flexible workers had been collocated with their managers for a significant period of time (between 2 and 10 years) prior to flexible working. They had consequently already developed trusting relationships enabling them to work successfully face to face. They worked autonomously without significant supervision and frequently met with colleagues, to catch up on local issues and office politics. This understanding of the background of the situation into which a system will be implemented is important. It provides the basis for exploring potential trust issues and people's expectations of each other. If someone is designing a flexible working system for people who do not share these

past experiences there is a good chance that the outcome will be different.

Another important factor that system designers should be aware of is the attitudes of the potential users since this will affect uptake and usage. In this particular case, individuals volunteered for flexible working. This provided an initial feeling of trust on the part of both flexible workers and managers. The flexible workers felt respected at having a choice about their work method and the managers recognised the commitment given to the flexible working initiative by these individuals. In addition, nearly all the individuals were themselves involved in setting up the flexible working pilot. This says a great deal about the positive attitude with which the flexible workers started. The managers' attitude was that their most important challenge was to ensure that flexible workers and office-based people continued to feel part of the team, and that flexible workers did not feel isolated. These positive and altruistic attitudes facilitated feelings of trust between all the team members.

Work culture can differ significantly between individuals in an organisation. The difference in culture is a key factor to be considered, particularly when importing a successful solution into a different context. Before introducing flexible working into LSEC, people worked autonomously with little supervision. Occasionally they worked from home when they really needed to concentrate. A significant aspect of the culture being proposed was that flexible workers would be able to choose where and when to work, depending on their tasks, other work commitments, and family circumstances. The fact that managers trusted the flexible workers to operate in this way, without constant surveillance, showed the degree of trust that had built up prior to flexible working. If a period of working together had not existed, and trust had not been established, the managers may not have felt at ease allowing the flexible workers to function without significant monitoring.

Situational context

The ABC Trust Model was next used to explore context. Systems designers need to establish an understanding of the situation into which their system will be implemented so that they can design with this context in mind. Ideally they should also use the model to explore similar situations.

The type of task performed, competence and available technical support, will affect a managers' level of trust of flexible working. In the case study the tasks performed by the flexible workers predominantly consisted of software programming, analysis and design. Other aspects of the job included report writing, liaising with customers and attending meetings. Also a few flexible workers were managers of others.

An audit took place to ensure appropriate equipment was made available, and the level of technical support was highlighted as an issue that needed to be resolved prior to the commencement of flexible working.

One key advantage that these individuals had when deciding to do flexible working, was knowledge of their managers and of each other. Individuals and their managers had already established respect for each other and knew each other's strengths, weaknesses and preferences. This meant that the flexible working system did not also need to help people get to know each other.

One regularly quoted barrier to starting flexible working is that managers fear they will lose control over their subordinates [17]. In this case the autonomy of the individuals and the knowledge and trust built over time, meant that managers did not want to introduce additional control mechanisms, such as monitoring flexible workers logging on to computer systems. Introducing such control mechanisms with experienced, autonomous workers is likely to lead to distrust and demotivation. In this case the only mechanisms used were the same as those used in the office — personal objectives, individual counselling and annual appraisals. Any need to introduce new control mechanisms should be carefully considered for other implementations of flexible working.

The personal incentives to do something often explain peoples' desire to become involved in potentially risky situations. Risky situations are identified as those where misuse of the trustee's trust by the trusted party will lead to negative consequences for the trustee. The greater the incentives, the more the trustee will want to trust others in that situation. Understanding incentives also helps systems designers develop success criteria for evaluating the system. For flexible working to be successful it has to be designed to meet the requirements of both flexible workers and their managers. In this case, individuals wanted increased flexibility about where and when they work, reduced travel time and more spare personal time. The managers wanted to reduce costs, increase flexibility and increase productivity.

The above analysis has enabled researchers to establish the following antecedents of trust:

- insights into the flexible workers' innate trust,
- insights into the managers' innate trust,
- an understanding of the flexible working context.

Since subjective trust is defined as 'innate trust' within a context, they also developed an insight into:

- flexible workers' level of subjective trust,
- managers' level of subjective trust.

4.2 Behavioural elements

The ABC Trust Model shows that expected behaviour is a combination of peoples' levels of subjective trust, the levels of risk they perceive, and the importance of the outcome for these individuals.

In the case being considered, prior to flexible working, individuals and their managers identified several concerns and perceived risks of starting to do flexible working. The risks identified by the individuals were:

- feeling isolated,
- being overlooked compared with more visible office-based colleagues at times of training allocation, getting the best work and promotion prospects,
- being unable to work effectively if equipment and networks were unreliable,
- feeling frustrated and de-motivated when things go wrong.

Managers also identified risks prior to flexible working. These risks were:

- flexible working may not suit these individuals,
- the investment in time, money and effort may be wasted,
- unreliable technology and networks may lead to ineffective working,
- the team may become demotivated and difficult to bond together.

The identified risks were significant. However, making flexible working successful was of great importance to these flexible workers and their managers because they wanted to gain specific benefits. Therefore individuals and managers were prepared to weigh up the risks, based on whether they could trust each other and what the possible negative and positive consequences might be. From this they decided to implement flexible working.

In terms of the three questions posed earlier, it would be predicted that, if they implemented flexible working:

- managers would be able to trust flexible workers to work without face-to-face supervision — this is due among other things to the relationship that they had already established and the dedication of the flexible workers to make the flexible working successful,

- flexible workers would trust their managers to treat them fairly compared with office-based colleagues — this prediction is based on the attitude of the managers and the good working relationship with which the flexible workers and their managers were starting,
- flexible workers would trust their technology to help them work effectively because it is the appropriate technology for their work, they have the necessary skills to use it, and technical support will be provided.

4.3 Consequences

The actual consequences of the flexible working case are now considered using data gathered 18 months after the flexible working began. The consequences are examined in relation to the three questions above.

- How can managers trust individuals to work effectively without face-to-face supervision?

The key consequence of the flexible working experience was that many managers developed a very positive attitude towards flexible working. For example, one said: 'It is great; please let your people try it'. The managers found that flexible working did not have a negative influence on their working relationship with the flexible workers. They felt this was largely due to the flexible workers and themselves being fully committed to making it work. This highlights the importance of involving people in the design and implementation of new systems, so that their attitudes and commitment levels are high from the start.

The managers in this case trusted individuals to work effectively without face-to-face supervision because flexible working had a positive influence on productivity, customer satisfaction and flexible workers' motivation. Managers found that the flexible workers were more motivated due to less travelling and less complicated personal arrangements.

Most customers believed that the commitment of flexible workers was higher and felt that the quantity and quality of work had increased. Other customers had not even noticed flexible working was taking place.

The flexible workers reported a strong sense of belonging to their team. They felt they exchanged sufficient information with their team and mostly felt they had sufficient contact with others outside their team.

The main problem faced by managers was making sure flexible workers were available for team meetings at the office. Also some managers found they wanted to know the whereabouts of the flexible workers and

wanted to be able to contact them within one hour. For this purpose a 'whereabouts' diary was set up on the intranet so that flexible workers and managers could nearly always contact each other. The use of the whereabouts diary increased the trust of the managers that they could contact flexible workers. The flexible workers could see the benefits of making their whereabouts available and were happy to conform.

A few managers felt it was easier to manage the flexible workers because they already knew them. Some were concerned about the possibility of managing flexible workers whom they did not previously know. This has implications for the design of systems. Where people can get together face to face, a good investment of time is to get to know each other before starting to work remotely. However, this cannot always be the case. Systems need to be designed to enable people to understand each other's motives, backgrounds, expectations, skills and abilities, thus minimising the risk of co-operating with unknown people.

- What enables individuals to trust managers to treat them fairly compared with their more visible office-based colleagues?

Interviews with the flexible workers showed that one of the consequences of their flexible working was that they felt it had not affected their status, either detrimentally or positively, suggesting that they felt fairly treated. This is probably due to them being treated the same as their office-based colleagues in terms of work allocation, feedback and job opportunities.

Some flexible workers had started to fear that moving to a different job would conflict with flexible working since a different manager may not accept their work style. They nearly all said they would not take a new job if they were not allowed to continue flexible working. This indicates that they would be prepared to be managed remotely by managers whom they do not know, but that they felt that managers who do not trust them would not allow them to do flexible working. This highlights the need to share the findings of new initiatives, such as flexible working, with others who do not yet understand the issues and benefits.

All the managers felt it was an important task for them to ensure that flexible workers did not feel left out. Most of the flexible workers were satisfied with the level of supervision they received although some said they would prefer more regular feedback. Some flexible workers felt that managers should try to find the time to make at least one visit to their homeworking environment. This would help the manager to get a feel

for the associated issues and problems and increase their mutual understanding leading to a more trusting relationship.

The flexible workers felt that their managers had a suitable management style for flexible working — open, inclusive and *laissez-faire*, instead of controlling and hands on. The autonomy of the flexible workers in deciding where and when to work meant that they immediately felt trusted. Since they did not want to lose that trust, they worked hard at making flexible working successful. The amount of control needed in different systems needs to be considered but it shouldn't be introduced just because people are no longer visible.

On the whole, individuals were able to trust managers to treat them fairly compared with their more visible office-based colleagues.

- How can flexible workers trust their technology to help them work effectively?

Only one person in this case study found that some tasks were not possible at home due to the absence of the right information or equipment. This suggests that generally the technology enabled people to be effective.

Most of the flexible workers felt the communications they received were up to date and accurate. However, there were a lot of comments about the 'river of information' of e-mail, and voicemail. With respect to information overload, people sometimes also found it hard to find the right information on the Internet/intranet. This may have a negative effect on trust in technology, especially if important information gets lost among all the other information.

One interviewee said there was a disadvantage in being contactable all the time: "With the mobile telephone turned on and the number of voicemail and e-mail messages, it seemed impossible to escape any more." To maintain trusting relationships, the flexible workers and managers need to understand this issue further and develop a rule that suits everyone. For example, the flexible worker could promise to check and respond to messages once an hour, or they might agree to concentrate on their work in the morning and take calls after lunch. Any system being designed needs to be flexible enough to incorporate different user preferences about communication patterns.

The most frequently mentioned advice was to keep in touch with colleagues. Flexible workers recommended going into the office for face-to-face contact at least once a week. One person said that, until he started flexible working, he had not realised that office small talk was an important channel of communication, rather than being just recreational. Also, many said that

face-to-face meetings were still needed, especially with customers. Face-to-face contact helps maintain and develop trusting relationships between all team members. The implication for flexible working systems is that they should not rely solely on technology for communication. They should be designed to support face-to-face communication, possibly by providing a suitable venue and opportunity for meeting.

It can be seen that the majority of flexible workers trust that their technology will help them work fairly effectively when away from the office. However, they realise its limitations and still like to go in to the office regularly, and still find it a useful venue for customer meetings. Key problems identified were information overload, not being able to escape from contact when necessary and missing out on office small talk. These areas could potentially be improved when designing future flexible working initiatives or technological systems to help people communicate effectively.

4.4 *Monitoring of performance*

The consequences of the flexible working pilot scheme have been discussed. These consequences took the form of decisions, actions, transactions and attitude change. These consequences will have affected the flexible workers' and the managers' perceptions of their relationship. For example, managers found that their anxieties about whether workers would be suited to flexible working were unfounded. In the future they will be more likely to delegate work to them and they may even consider building working relationships with people whom they do not initially know.

From the flexible worker's point of view, they felt fairly treated by the managers, therefore their knowledge and perception about the managers' ability has changed for the better. As a result of their experience, their trust in the capabilities of the equipment has increased. However, other issues relating to continuation of flexible working may be in their minds. For example, the need to escape from being contactable all the time, and the issue of progressing their careers and continuing flexible working. It can be deduced that building relationships is an incremental process. Long-term evaluation of the effectiveness of new systems is therefore needed to see whether they continue to be successful, what new perceived risks have been introduced, and how the system can be improved. Participants were asked what their success criteria were and measurements were made against these, but their needs, and hence criteria, may change over time and should be reconsidered in long-term evaluations.

5. Discussion and conclusions

The academic literature on trust is spread across different subject areas. The early research (e.g. Worchel [8]) focused on the psychological implications of trust for individual behaviour, and organisation theorists have expanded these concepts into the broader area of relationship development between individuals and organisations. In this paper a theoretical model of trust has been proposed that relates the notion of trust antecedents to behavioural elements and consequences. The model distinguishes between two types of trust — innate trust and subjective trust. Innate trust exists independently of a situation and is a function of the individual or organisation's make-up and history. Subjective trust is a function of the innate level of trust and the situational factors such as the knowledge of the partner and the nature of the transaction.

This paper shows the validation of the trust model using a flexible working programme to check whether the model is complete and how it is likely to be used in a business context. The model was used to explore the existing and potential relationships between flexible workers and their manager. In its simplest form the model can be used as a checklist to ensure all necessary aspects of the relationship have been addressed. The model was used to discover the factors affecting levels of trust between the flexible workers and their managers. This research suggests that the model is largely complete but further usage will allow it to be updated as necessary. It was found that to use the model successfully it must be applied to a single relationship (e.g. flexible worker and manager) since looking at too many relationships can become very complex. Also it was found easiest to focus the model on particular issues of interest if it was used to address key research questions. The consequences of a situation can then be examined with these questions in mind. One key characteristic of the model is that it can be applied at different points in time to show how relationships change.

The case study analysis highlighted additional implications of events which may affect flexible workers, e.g. the importance of being able to contact flexible workers within a reasonable time, not just because of the direct impact on productivity but also because lack of contactability may undermine the trust relationship between the worker and their manager as it feeds back into the situational context. The case study shows the development of trust between parties and clarifies how consequences of trusting behaviour have affected others' perceptions and the level of risk involved.

Consideration of what made the flexible working programme successful demonstrates the central importance of trust between the different parties. The research shows that the implementation of flexible working was successful because the motivations and trust levels of all parties were

high to start with and efforts were made on all sides to maintain those levels of trust.

It is likely that organisations and individuals will continue to experiment with novel organisational forms in response to an unstable and complex business environment. This will result in individual workers operating remotely from offices and colleagues, and employees from different organisations contributing to products and processes of virtual organisations. It has been argued that trust will be an important factor in the effective development of relationships in remote working and other virtual forms of work.

Future research opportunities lie in applying the model to business situations where the outcome of organisational changes are unknown, thus using the model to predict where issues of trust and changes in relationships are likely to occur and comparing consequences with the model's predictions. Also the model should be used to explore inter-organisational business formation and business opportunities such as trading in global markets, telemedicine, on-line education, retail marketing over the World Wide Web. The model could also be used to explore the design and implementation of innovative technologies, such as audio-graphics conferencing and virtual environments, to see if they could be designed in a way to engender trust and co-operation by understanding how trust in relationships is affected by change in cultural and physical distance.

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